Gravissimo officii munere

Pius X · 1906-08-10 · English

To His Venerable Brethren, the Archbishops and Bishops of France, Pius X, Pope.

Venerable Brethren, Health and the Apostolic Benediction.

We are going to discharge to-day a very grave obligation of Our office, an obligation which We assumed towards you when We an- nounced, after the promulgation of the law creating a rupture between the French Republic and the Church, that We should indicate at a fitting time what it might seem to Us ought to be done to defend and preserve the religion of your country. We have allowed you to wait until to-day for the satisfaction of your desires, by reason not only of the importance of this great question, but also, and above all, by reason of the quite special charity which binds Us to you and to all your interests because of the unforgettable services rendered to the Church by your nation.

"Therefore, after having condemned, as was our duty, this iniqui- tous law, We have inquired with the greatest care whether the articles of the said law would leave Us any means of organizing religious life in France in such a way as to protect from injury the sacred prin- ciples on which the Holy Church reposes. To this end, it appeared good to Us both to take the counsel of the assembled episcopate and to prescribe for your general assembly the points which ought to be the principal objects of your deliberations. And now, knowing your views, as well as those of several Cardinals, and after having maturely reflected and implored by the most fervent prayers the Father of Light, We see that We ought to confirm fully by Our Apostolic authority the almost unanimous decision of your assembly."

It is for this reason that, with reference to the religious associa- tions as the law establishes them, We decree that it is absolutely impossible for them to be admitted without a violation of the sacred rights pertaining to the very life of the Church.

Let Us put aside, therefore, these associations which the knowledge of Our duty forbids Us to approve.

It might appear opportune to examine whether it is lawful to make trial in their place of some other sort of associations at once legal and canonical, and thus to preserve the Catholics of France from the grave complications which menace them.

Of a certainty nothing so engrosses and distresses Us as these eventualities, and would to Heaven that We had some hope of being able, without infringing the rights of God, to make this essay, and thus to deliver Our well-beloved sons from the fear of such great trials.

But as this hope fails Us while the law remains what it is, We declare that it is not permissible to try this other kind of associations as long as it is not established in a sure and legal manner that the Divine constitution of the Church, the immutable rights of the Roman Pontiff and of the Bishops, and their authority over the necessary property of the Church, particularly over the sacred edifices, shall be irrevocably vested in the said associations in full security. To desire the contrary is impossible for Us. It would be to betray the sanctity of Our Office without bringing peace to the Church of Prance.

It remains, therefore, for you, venerable brothers, to set yourselves to the work, to employ all means which the law recognizes as within the rights of all citizens to organize religious worship. In a matter so important and so arduous you will never have to wait for Our assistance. Absent in body, We shall be with you in thought and in heart. We shall aid you on every occasion with Our counsel and with Our authority.

Assume with courage the burden We impose upon you under the inspiration of Our love for the Church and for your country. Trust in everything else to the provident goodness of God, Whose help We are firmly convinced will, when He so chooses, not fail France.

It is not difficult to foresee the nature of the recriminations the enemies of the Church will make against Our present decree and Our orders. They will endeavor to persuade the people that We have not had the interests of the Church of Prance solely in view; that We have had another design foreign to religion, that the form of the Republic in Prance is hateful to Us, that in order to overthrow it We are seconding the efforts of the parties hostile to her, that We refuse to Prance that which the Holy See has without difficulties accorded to her nations. These recriminations, with others of the same sort, which, as can be foreseen from certain indications, will be disseminated among the public in order to excite irritation, We de- nounce now and henceforth with the utmost indignation as false; and it is incumbent upon yon, venerable brothers, as upon all good men,

to refute them in order that they may not deceive simple and ignorant people.

With reference to the special charge against the Church of having been more accommodating in a similar case outside France, you should explain that the Church has acted in this way because the situations ■were quite different, and, above all, because the divine attributes of the Hierarchy were, in a certain measure, safeguarded. If any State has separated from the Church, -while leaving to her the resource of the liberty common to all and the free disposal of her property, that State has without doubt and on more than one ground acted unjustly ; but nevertheless it could not be said that it has created an absolutely intolerable situation for the Church. But it is quite otherwise to-day in France. There the fabricators of this unjust law wished to make it a law, not of separation, but of oppression. Thus they affirmed their desire for peace and promised an understanding; and they are now waging an atrocious war against the religion of the country. They hurl the firebrands of the most violent discords, and thus incite the citizens against each other, to the great detriment, as every one sees, of the public welfare itself.

Assuredly they will tax their ingenuity to throw the blame for this conflict and for the evils resulting therefrom upon Us. But who- ever loyally examines the facts of which "We have spoken in the Encyclical "Vehementer Nos" will be able to see whether We have deserved the least reproach. "We, who, after having patiently sup- ported injustice upon injustice in Our love for the proud French nation, finally find Ourselves bound over to transgress the last holy limits of Our Apostolic duty, and We declare that We will not trans- gress them, or rather We ask whether the fault does not lie entirely with those who in hate of the Apostolic name have gone to such extremities.

Therefore, if they desire to show Us their submission and their devotion, let the Catholic men of France struggle for the Church in accordance with the directions We have already given them— that is to say, with perseverance and energy, and yet without acting in a seditious and violent manner. It is not by violence, but by firmness, that, fortifying themselves in their good right as within a citadel, they will succeed in breaking the obstinacy of their enemies. Let them well understand, as We have said and as We repeat, that their efforts will be useless unless they unite in a perfect understanding for the defence of religion. As they now know Our verdict on the subject of this nefarious law, they should whole-heartedly conform to it, and whatever the opinions of some or others of them may have been hitherto during the discussion of the question, We entreat all that no one shall permit himself to wound any one whomsoever on the pretext that his own way of seeing is the best. What can be done by concord of will and union of forces, let them learn from their adversaries, and just as the latter were able to impose on the nation the stigma of this criminal law, so Our people will be able to eliminate and remove it.

In this hard trial of France, if all those who wish to defend with all their power the supreme interests of their country, work as they ought to do in union among themselves, with their Bishops, and with Ourselves for the cause of religion, far from despairing of the welfare of the Church of France, it is to be hoped on the contrary that that Church will be restored to her pristine prosperity and dignity. "We in no way doubt that the Catholics will fully comply with Our direc- tions, and conform with Our desires. Also, We shall ardently seek to obtain for them, by the intercession of Mary the Immaculate Vir- gin, the aid of the Divine goodness. As a pledge of this celestial gift and in testimony of Our paternal benevolence, We grant with all Our heart the Apostolic Benediction to you, venerable brothers, and to the whole French nation.

Given at Rome, St. Peter's, on August 10, the Feast of St Law- rence the Martyr, in the year 1906, the fourth of Our Pontificate.

Pros PP.X.

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